

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Late tax payouts put libraries in bind

Many come close to crisis as problems with a tech upgrade stall Cook County’s revenue distributions

By **A.D. Quig**
Chicago Tribune

Village library leaders have added their voices to the chorus of complaints about delayed and sporadic distributions of Cook County property tax revenues, saying the situation has drained their reserves, making it harder to hire or buy new books.

And in the latest complication in Cook County’s ongoing property tax woes, about \$175 million in excess money was sent to taxing bodies that weren’t expecting it.

Echoing problems first publicly raised by suburban school district

leaders, a subset of public library directors reported they have had to go into “ongoing financial triage” because property tax receipts that typically land in their bank accounts in the summer were months late.

Libraries received the bulk of their expected dollars last week and are expected to be made entirely whole this week. But in a memo shared with the Tribune, a group of library leaders said in recent months they’ve had to put off payments to vendors, paused new hires and canceled or scaled back public programs.

The impact on libraries is

another wrinkle in the long-delayed upgrade of the county’s internal property tax systems with contractor Tyler Technologies. Though taxpayers settled their bills between mid-November and December, it has taken extra time to get those dollars into the bank accounts of cities, park districts, schools and libraries.

Village library districts have teamed up to note they’ve waited even longer for significant funds to flow compared with their city or school district counterparts. Because they are considered “sub-agencies” whose levies are approved by municipal boards, they didn’t receive stopgap emergency funding from Cook County

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Charlize Hernandez, from left, Evalize Hernandez, and Daniel and Luis Sanchez play with magnets at Hillside Public Library on Friday. While most taxing bodies had received about 87% of their due taxes near the end of January, Hillside had received just 10%. **JOSH BOLAND/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



A delivery robot from Serve Robotics crosses the 1600 block of North Wells Street in Chicago on Wednesday. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Convenient ordering option or ‘sidewalk hog’?

Food delivery robots get mixed reception in Chicago; rollout faces growing pushback

By **Robert Channick**
and **Talia Soglin**
Chicago Tribune

The rise of autonomous food delivery in Chicago has made colorful, flag-bearing robotic carts a familiar sight as they steadily roll along busy sidewalks and crosswalks on a last-mile mission to transport tacos.

But as their robotic ranks swell, there have been an increasing number of incidents pitting man against machine, from side-

walk standoffs and traffic jams to a handful of collisions. Just ask DePaul-area resident Janice Hughes, who claims she was rear-ended by a Coco robot while raking the parkway in front of her home.

“They’re sidewalk hogs,” said Hughes, 66. “They don’t have the education or ability to recognize how to curb themselves.”

The red Coco robots, which have been traversing Chicago since late 2024, were joined last fall by a fleet of green units from Serve Robotics. Together, dozens

of self-driving robots have already logged more than 29,000 sidewalk miles and delivered nearly 28,000 food orders, according to city statistics.

While some Chicagoans have taken to the futuristic delivery service, others have not exactly rolled out the welcome wagon for the army of AI-driven meals on wheels. Notably, one Coco robot ended up sleeping with the fishes last summer after it was apparently abducted by unknown assailants and dumped in a canal,

according to a company report to the city.

The companies behind the robots say they are safe, and only a few incidents involving the devices have been reported to the city. But amid anecdotal struggles to share the sidewalk, there is a growing movement to slow the robot rollout, including petition drives, residential meetings and rumblings of political pressure to reexamine the pilot program.

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Questions rise from political snub

Cook County Board President Preckwinkle says she didn’t seek teachers union’s endorsement

By **Alice Yin**
Chicago Tribune

When the Chicago Teachers Union unveiled its latest political endorsement last week ahead of the March primary, one name was notably absent: Toni Preckwinkle.

The boss of the Cook County Democrats, seeking her fifth term as Cook County Board president, then revealed to reporters that she did not want the progressive

labor juggernaut’s support.

“I didn’t seek their endorsement,” Preckwinkle told reporters Thursday, before rattling off a list of unions like the Chicago Federation of Labor and other left-leaning groups who are backing her campaign. “And I’m proud of those endorsements,” she said. “I’ve also been endorsed by the governor of the state, JB Pritzker, the speaker of the House and the president of the Senate.”

Preckwinkle didn’t elaborate on her reason. Nor did she mention Mayor Brandon Johnson, who has not endorsed her reelection bid so far.

But the former public school teacher’s choice to skip the CTU’s endorsement slate, which has long been viewed as an early signal to progressives about which candidates they should coalesce around, was striking.

Under heavy fire from political opponents, the union and its close ally Johnson have been

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Cook County Board President Toni Preckwinkle speaks during a news conference on Dec. 31. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Reports of ICE ruses add to fears

Agents dressing as construction workers, activists, some say

By **Jake Offenhartz**
Associated Press

MINNEAPOLIS — For days, Luis Ramirez had an uneasy feeling about the men dressed as utility workers he’d seen outside his family’s Mexican restaurant in suburban Minneapolis.

They wore high-visibility vests and spotless white hard hats, he noticed, even while parked in their vehicle. His search for the Wisconsin-based electrician advertised on the car’s doors returned no results.

On Tuesday, when their Nissan returned to the lot outside his restaurant, Ramirez, 31, filmed his confrontation with the two men, who hid their faces as he approached and appeared to be wearing heavy tactical gear beneath their yellow vests.

“This is what our taxpayer money goes to: renting these vehicles with fake tags to come sit here and watch my business,” Ramirez shouted in the video.

A spokesperson for the Department of Homeland Security and Immigration and Customs Enforcement did not

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INSIDE



BRIAN CASSELLA/TRIBUNE

Winter Walk aids Chicago’s homeless

Hundreds of community members, nonprofit workers and formerly homeless people walked through Humboldt Park on Sunday to raise awareness and money for homelessness. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Vonn breaks leg in Olympics crash

U.S. ski racer Lindsey Vonn’s defiant bid to win the Winter Olympic downhill on a rebuilt right knee and a badly injured left knee ended with a frightening crash Sunday. **Chicago Sports**

